

Farewell, Comrades

India's seniormost pro bids goodbye to two of his oldest and most illustrious teammates who have left international cricket with glittering deeds and poignant memories

It has not sunk in yet but in a few days time, I know it will. At the end of the series against Australia this week, India will find itself without two of its most distinguished cricketers. Two of my oldest teammates won't be part of my dressing room any more. Anil Kumble came to me during the warm-ups on the last day of the Delhi Test and told me about his decision to quit. I didn't know what to do; he has been part of my cricket since 1990. Sourav Ganguly had announced his decision to go in the dressing room in Bangalore and I was surprised about it as we had never had any discussion of the sort. There is always a sadness about retirements of teammates with whom you have

played for so long. But I believe the individual knows best about the state of his mind and his body and so the decision to retire should be respected.

No two cricketers are alike, no two people are and so it is with Anil and Sourav. You have to respect and accept difference and acknowledge and appreciate the varied talents and skills that different players bring into a dressing room.

Persistence and consistency was Anil's strength and he reinvented himself all the time. Every couple of seasons he came up with a few new deliveries and I saw how much he pushed his body to the limit all the time. He put his body on the line for cricket for so long. In any list of India's great-



ANIL AND SOURAV WERE DIFFERENT PLAYERS, BUT THEY WILL INSPIRE GENERATIONS OF CRICKETERS

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